Edutainment: Can Reality Television Prevent Teenage Pregnancy?

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ABSTRACT

Reality television is more than shallow entertainment. A growing array of "do good" reality productions claim to educate TV viewers, transform lives, guide behavior, and create better members of society, in addition to entertaining audiences, selling products and generating high ratings. Programs such as *Dad Camp, Baby Borrowers, and 16 and Pregnant* are examples of reality based productions that combine commercial entertainment agendas with a public service mission to prevent teenage pregnancy and improve parental skills. This study looks at partnerships between commercial television and non-profit agencies responsible for the programs. In addition it reviews patterns that occur within the programs, and the nature of resources (including advice, information and services) they provide to teenage TV viewers.



PURPOSE OF RESEARCH

This study was completed as a part of a larger research project conducted by Dr. Laurie Ouellette. Dr. Ouellette's project, which is entitled "It's Not TV, It's Birth Control: Reality Television and the Problem of Teenage Pregnancy," examines television programs from different eras that claim to educate teenagers about sexual education and life planning, in partnership with non-profit agencies as well as television sponsors. As a part of that study this research was conducted to provide information about three well known, contemporary reality television programs that were created to 1) discourage pregnancy among young, unmarried teenagers 2) to educate young fathers about the importance of taking responsibility for their children. The programs investigated were *Dad Camp, The Baby Borrowers,* and *16 and Pregnant*. Detailed textual analysis of 51 episodes were conducted and coded according to pre-determined themes. This research will examine the mission of these programs, the nature of the information and resources they provide, and the educational messages of the programs, particularly with regard to sexual education, birth control, life planning, and "personal responsibility".

RESULTS

Dad Camp

- Intended to reveal the responsibilities of young parenting and demonstrate the time, energy and skills required to be a proper parent.

Demonstrates:

- ✓Saving money
- ✓Parental involvement
- ✓How to improve parenting skills
- ✓ Continuing your education
- ✓ Seeking help for chemical dependencies
- ✓ Controlling anger management

- Dad Camp does not mention the topics of abortion, resources available for unexpected pregnancies, or birth control (it was not created for this purpose). 20% of the episodes watched discussed and encouraged marriage as an essential component of active parenting.

The Baby Borrowers

- Intended to decrease the amount of teen pregnancies in the U.S. and the U.K.
- Places human subjects in experimental situations while the cameras roll, with the purpose of discouraging pregnancy at too young an age. Teen couples are given actual children to care for in three day increments. The children's age begins with infancy and increases through early teen years and then skips to senior citizens. Because the scenarios are highly staged to emphasize hardship and stress, there is no way to conclusively evaluate their effectiveness. *The Baby Borrowers* does not discuss resources available for unplanned pregnancies nor does it mention abortion. The educational focus is on individual decision-making and life planning.
- Discusses birth control 40% of the time, with the parents of the "borrowed" children advocating prevention. Marriage (as an essential component of parenthood) is encouraged in 20% of the episodes analyzed.

16 & Pregnant

- Intended to prevent unplanned and teen pregnancies.

Demonstrates:

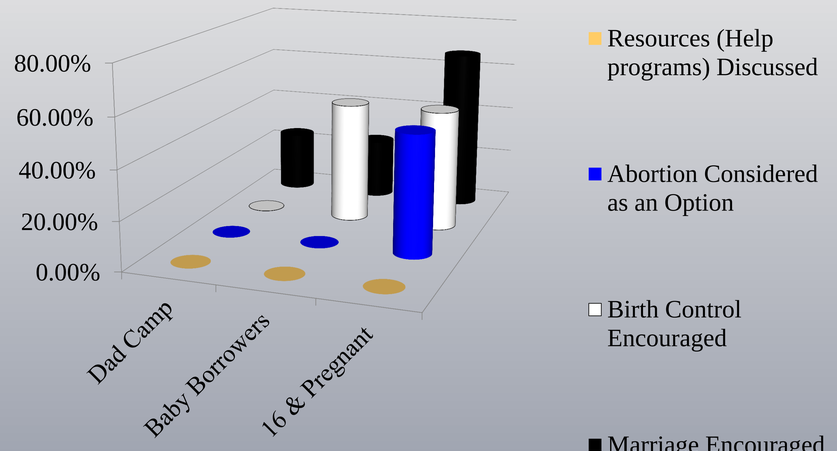
- ✓ Documents real events that have occurred in the lives of teenagers who unexpectantly became teen parents.
- ✓ Televises the difficult moments of pregnancy and parenting, particularly for young people.
- ✓ Emphasizes how and why it is difficult to be a teen parent due to lack of education, life experience, training, and work experience.

- Season one does not mention resources for teen parents. It does mention birth control 60% of the time; adoption is a prominent theme, and marriage and marriage counseling are discussed.
- Season two does mention resources for expectant teen parents, their parents, and teens who are sexually active . Adoption remains a prominent theme.
- No subject filmed during seasons 1 and 2 chooses abortion as a solution to teen pregnancy.

FUTURE QUESTIONS

- How do schools and community groups use these TV programs in their educational efforts?
- How do teenage TV viewers make sense of these programs?
- What do teenage TV viewers the learn from the initiatives?
- What aspects of the programs and their messages are emphasized to TV viewers?
- How are these shows and their missions impacted by their uptake in the tabloid media, which made celebrities of the teenage subjects?
- Have trends in teen pregnancy and parental involvement changed since these shows were produced?

Occurances mentioned in the Programs:	*Dad Camp*	*Baby Borrowers*	*16 & Pregnant*
Resources (Help programs) Discussed	0.00%	0.00%	0.00%
Abortion Considered as an Option	0.00%	0.00%	50.00%
Birth Control Encouraged	0.00%	50.00%	50.00%
Marriage Encouraged	25.00%	25.00%	67.00%



Programs:	*Dad Camp*	*Baby Borrowers*	*16 & Pregnant*
Non-Profit Partners	National Fatherhood Leadership Group	National Council to Prevent Teen and Unplanned Pregnancy	National Council to Prevent Teen and Unplanned Pregnancy
Television Networks	VH-1	NBC	MTV
Program Objectives	Increase responsibility awareness of young fathers	Reduce teen pregnancy	Reduce teen pregnancy